

Setup Zoho Creator and exploring Platform Exploration

Author: Midhun J

Roll no: 241401055

1. Objective & Scope

This document records a hands-on exploration of **Zoho Creator**, a low-code application development platform. The goal is to understand how an application is built from scratch — from account setup through to a published, working app — and to note the platform's key building blocks: forms, workflows, reports, pages, permissions, and deployment.

Each section below documents one area of the platform: the steps taken to explore it, and a placeholder for a screenshot captured during that step.

2. Getting Started — Account & Dashboard

The first step was signing in and getting oriented within the Zoho Creator home environment before building anything.

1. Signed in to Zoho Creator using a Zoho account (or created a new trial account at creator.zoho.com).
2. Landed on the Creator dashboard, which lists all existing applications (empty on first login).
3. Reviewed the top navigation — options to create a new application, browse templates, or import an existing app.
4. Noted the workspace/account switcher, used when a user belongs to multiple Zoho organizations.

Observation: The dashboard is intentionally sparse — the platform pushes the user toward either “Create New Application” or a template gallery immediately, rather than requiring any setup first.

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All Apps

+ Create Application



Student Attendance Form

Created on Aug 01, 2026

Application

More

Edit

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Here is your Smart Chat (Ctrl+Space)

Get started faster!

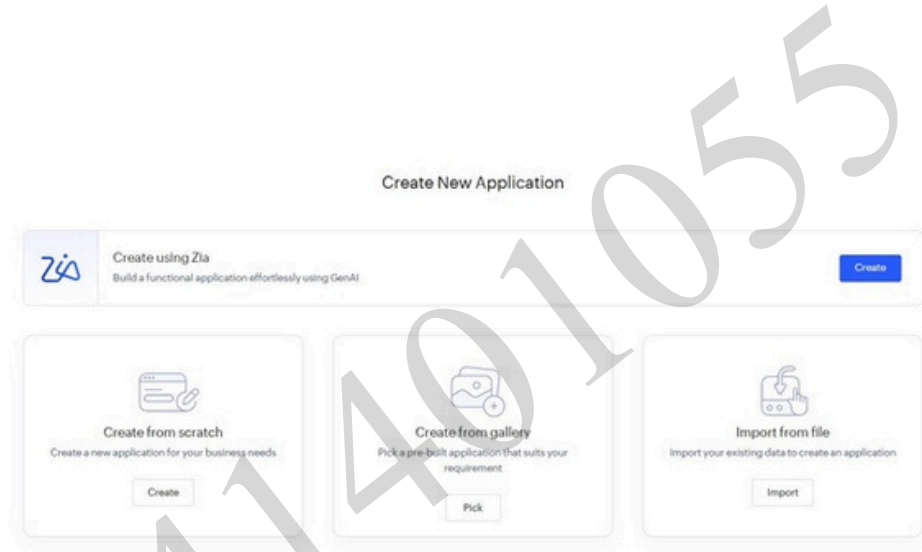
Help

3. Creating a New Application

This step covered the actual app-creation flow, including the choice between building from scratch versus starting from a template.

1. Clicked “Create New Application” from the dashboard.
2. Chose between: (a) building from scratch, (b) starting from a pre-built template (e.g. CRM, Inventory, Helpdesk), or (c) importing an existing spreadsheet/data source.
3. Named the application and selected the target environment/workspace.
4. Landed inside the application's build environment, showing the empty forms/pages/workflow structure.

Observation: Starting from a template pre-populates forms, fields, and even sample workflows — useful for seeing what a “complete” app looks like before building one from a blank canvas.



4. Form Builder — Fields & Layout

Forms are the primary data-entry and data-model building block in Zoho Creator. This section covers the drag-and-drop form designer.

1. Opened the Form Builder and created a new form (e.g. “Customer Requests”).
2. Dragged field types from the left-hand panel onto the canvas — single line, dropdown, date, lookup, subform, file upload, etc.
3. Configured field-level properties: validation rules, default values, mandatory/optional status, and visibility conditions.
4. Added a lookup field to link this form's records to another form (relating two data tables).
5. Previewed the form as an end user would see it, and tested a sample submission.

Observation: Field configuration happens through property panels rather than code, but each field still maps to an underlying data column — confirming that the visual layer sits on top of a real schema, not a substitute for one.

The screenshot displays the Zoho Creator Form Builder interface. At the top, a dialog box asks "How would you like to create your form?". Below this, there are two main categories: "On my own" and "From a template".

On my own options include:

- From scratch (represented by a plus icon)
- Import with data (represented by a document icon)
- Using Zia (represented by the Zia logo)

From a template options include:

- Cab Booking (represented by a car icon)
- Conf Room Booking (represented by a chair icon)
- Appointment Booking (represented by a calendar icon)
- Hotel Room Booking (represented by a bed icon)
- Complaints (represented by a speech bubble icon)
- 50+ View More (represented by a plus icon)

Below the dialog, a preview of a "Student Attendance Form" is shown. The form has a title bar "Student Attendance Form" and a subtitle "Fill Attendance". The form is divided into two sections: "Basic Fields" and "Form Fields".

Basic Fields section includes:

- Name (with a person icon)
- Email (with an envelope icon)
- Address (with a location pin icon)
- Phone (with a telephone icon)
- Single Line (with a text input icon)
- Multi Line (with a text area icon)
- Number (with the number 123)
- Date (with a calendar icon)
- Time (with a clock icon)
- Drop Down (with a dropdown arrow icon)

Form Fields section includes:

- Name *
- Roll No *
- Department *
- Email *
- Phone *
- Session *
- Date *
- Time *

5. Workflow Automation (Deluge Scripting)

Zoho Creator's automation layer runs on **Deluge**, its built-in scripting language. This section covers both the no-code workflow triggers and a basic Deluge script.

1. Opened the Workflow section and created a new automation triggered “On Add” (i.e. when a new record is created).
2. Used the no-code action builder to configure a simple action — e.g. sending an email notification when a form is submitted.
3. Opened the Deluge script editor attached to the same trigger and wrote a short script to update a related field automatically.
4. Tested the workflow by submitting a sample record and confirming the automated action fired correctly.

Observation: This is the platform's “trapdoor” in practice: the no-code action builder covers common cases, but Deluge is available the moment logic needs to branch, loop, or call an external API.

The screenshot displays the Zoho Creator Workflow Automation interface. The top section, titled "Run workflow on any event in the form", allows users to configure a workflow. It includes a "Choose form" dropdown set to "Fill Attendance", a "Run when a record is (Record Event)" section with radio buttons for "Created", "Edited", "Created or Edited", and "Deleted", and a "When to trigger workflow (Form Event)" dropdown set to "-Select-". A "Name the workflow" field contains the text "Examples: Notify Customer, Calculate Sum". A blue "Create Workflow" button is located below these fields.

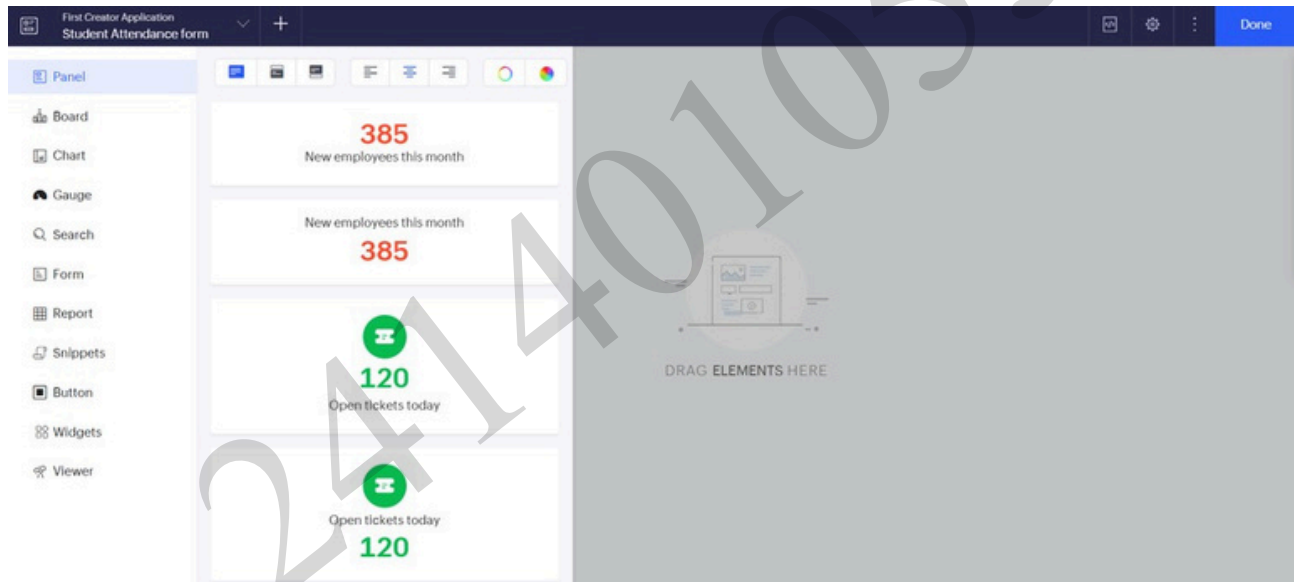
The bottom section, titled "Deluge Script", shows the script editor for the selected workflow. The breadcrumb trail at the top of the editor reads: "Fill Attendance > Created or Edited > Validations on form submission > Student Attendance form". The editor interface includes a left sidebar with a "Condition" section (containing "if", "else if", "else", and "conditional if" options) and a "Data Access" section (containing "add record", "fetch records", "aggregate records", "update record", "update multiple fields", "for each record", and "delete records" options). The main script area is currently empty. At the bottom right, there are "Save" and "Cancel" buttons.

6. Pages — Custom User Interface

Pages let a builder assemble a custom-designed screen (dashboards, landing screens, custom forms) beyond the default auto-generated form/report layouts.

1. Created a new Page and opened the page designer.
2. Added and arranged widgets — embedded reports, buttons, custom HTML/CSS blocks, and navigation elements.
3. Linked a button's click action to a workflow function (e.g. “Approve Request”) using the built-in action binding.
4. Previewed the page in both desktop and mobile layout modes.

Observation: Pages are where Zoho Creator moves closest to “real” front-end design, but layout is still constrained to the widgets and grid system the platform provides.



7. *Summary of Findings*

Key takeaways from this exploration:

- An application can go from blank to a working, published state without writing traditional code, using forms, workflows, reports, and pages as the core building blocks.
- Deluge scripting is available at nearly every automation point, giving a controlled escape hatch when the no-code tools aren't sufficient.

Overall, Zoho Creator matches the general low-code pattern: a *metadata-driven build experience* that compiles down to real, running application logic, with scripting reserved for the cases that fall outside the visual tools' coverage.

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